

Play, watch, create: Unpacking community views on esports, game-related content creation, & gameplay careers

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ABSTRACT

Despite the growing popularity of gaming content creators, esports, and professional videogaming in research, there is no clear, unified understanding of these concepts. Using a mixed-methods approach, we analysed how members of the gaming community (recreational players, esports players, content creators, and content consumers) defined game-related content, esports, and gameplaying careers. Participants ($N = 85$) from 18 countries completed an online questionnaire including Likert items and long-response options. We found “game-related content” was an umbrella term comprising *information dissemination*, *vicarious gaming*, and *competitive content* (e.g., esports). We developed the theme *season-bound events* as key in defining esports. Furthermore, most participants agreed that playing videogames could be a valid career, listing *income* and *exchange of goods and services* as their main justifications. This work is a fundamental first step to understanding the nature of gameplay careers, and establishing foundations for organisational classifications, worker rights, and safety policies for this emerging workforce.

1. Introduction

Research in videogames has rapidly been increasing in the academic world [1,2], with esports (electronic sports) as the driving force. Although research has investigated esports as a potential career pathway [2,3,4,5,6,7,8], a new trend of alternative game-playing careers has emerged in popular media and in recent videogaming research: being a gaming content creator. Although investigations have delved into game-related streaming and gaming YouTubers more broadly, there is still a lack of a comprehensive and homogeneous understanding of this phenomenon; gaming content or game-related content have not been explicitly identified, described, or operationalised [9]. Similarly, definitions of esports in the literature are largely heterogeneous and confined to the academic context despite the wealth of available research papers. Therefore, in this study, we turned to the videogaming community to investigate gaming content and esports, an underrepresented voice in the discussion of gaming and esports definitions. Furthermore, we presented the gaming community’s opinions about playing video games as a legitimate career pathway to direct future research based in community beliefs.

In this study, we first present a literature review of gaming content,

esports, and gameplaying careers, and how these concepts have previously been defined in the academic context. We then outline our research methodology for collecting the gaming community’s perspectives of said concepts and definitions, before presenting our findings and discussing their implications for future research, classification and worker protections.

1.1. Literature review

Traditionally, the relationship between videogames and entertainment was facilitated through the direct emersion of being an explicit participant in the videogame (i.e., the person playing the videogame is the one being entertained) [4,9]. However, videogaming as an entertainment medium has evolved such that being a spectator of videogaming can be just as enjoyable, if not more entertaining than playing the videogame oneself. Lin et al. [9] explained how this distance and imbalance of control and information for viewers creates unique tension and suspense, enhancing the entertainment garnered from videogaming action (gameplay). With the advancements of technology, videogaming spectating has shifted from physical crowds at the arcade to online crowds on videos, posts, and online communities made for and about

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videogaming. This digital broadcasting of videogaming is a new form of digital entertainment [5,10,11,12,13,14,15] and a new way to engage with video games with some researchers arguing that such gaming content may be a facilitator in gaming community and culture [13,16,17]. The potential role gaming content may have in gaming community and culture warrants further research. However, a comprehensive understanding of this phenomenon does not exist in the literature, limiting the occurrence of deep and extensive investigations.

The documentation, distribution, and commentary of gameplay are not entirely new ideas to academic research; spectating videogaming action is a large part of esports, an extensively researched gaming topic in the literature. However, esports is not the only form of gaming content, nor is it the primary genre. In 2020, there was ~ 902 million hours of live-streamed gaming content; only 13 % was competitive gaming content (e.g., esports) while the remaining 87 % was non-competitive gaming content [18]. These statistics raise a few questions: if the gaming content is not esports, then a) what is it, and b) what is it called? There are notable articles and researchers who are at the forefront of videogaming content, but descriptions are vague and the labels vary. Media depicting videogames or gaming have been called “in-game”, “game-related” content [19], and “user-generated content” [15]. More specifically, live distribution of gameplay has been called “live-streaming” [14,16,17], “game streaming”, and “game live streaming” interchangeably [12]; informal gameplay (often on YouTube) has been called “Let’s play” [20] and “Let’s Players” content” [13]. Johnson [16] has called creators of gaming media as “gaming content-creators” or “gaming content broadcasters”, whereas other researchers have used content-specific terms (e.g., “streamer” [9] and “let’s player” [13]).

Some of the most notable studies are the explorations of live-streaming and YouTube gameplay as separate entities despite researchers own results indicating overlap and interconnections. For example, Kreissl et al. [13] used live-streaming as a way to define let’s plays (e.g., let’s plays = non-live-streamed gameplay). Furthermore, two separate studies of live-streaming gameplay [16,17] found an overlap in YouTube gameplay work and live-streaming, with one participant explicitly describing esports, live-streaming and YouTube-ing as related entities when discussing the future of live-streaming [17]. Conversely, Smith et al. [20] described all game-related content creators as “players”, with terms such as streaming (Twitch) and pre-recorded videos (YouTube) being possible formats for gaming content. Furthermore, Smith et al. [20] highlighted the differential factor being game content type or genre, identifying the let’s play community, speedrunning community, and even the esports community as separate enough content types but are similar enough to exist in the umbrella concept of videogaming content and entertainment. Identification of the different gaming content present may be a more comprehensive categorisation system rather than by platform or medium, particularly in the case of esports.

Esports (as a phenomenon) has been characterised as a distinct form of videogaming in the literature, consisting of sponsored and broadcasted gaming events attracting viewers and spectators. However, as described above, other gaming content such as let’s plays that are broadcasted on platforms such as Twitch and YouTube can also garner the attention of spectators and sponsorships. The question raised then becomes “how is esports separate from other gaming content?”, with “a comprehensive definition” posing as an answer. However, such a definition or understanding within the academic community is still lacking, with a majority of researchers using a range of differing characteristics to operationalise or define esports. Formosa et al. [1] conducted a systematic review and thematic analysis of esports definitions in the literature to illustrate these inconsistencies. While a majority of authors may include aspects of sponsorships, fans and audiences, and prize pools to define esports [2,3,4,5,11,21], other characteristics such as competitiveness [1,3,7,11,22], organisation [1,2,3,22], professionalism [2,4,5,7,11,22] and comparisons to traditional sports [2,11] are not as consistent. Characteristics such as competitiveness or organisation may

be key to differentiating esports from other gaming content while professionalism comes with its own connotations (e.g., only esports can be professional).

Interesting is Smith et al.’s [20] grouping of esports being closely related to other gaming content such as speedrunning and let’s plays, possibly suggesting esports to not be a separate phenomenon but a genre of gaming content. Previous research has indicated some overlap among esports and gaming content, with esports players [3] and professional gamers [21] reporting that they perform esports behaviours and gaming content creation behaviours simultaneously. Other research investigating esports career pathways found that some professional esports players transitioned into gaming content creation [6,8], with retired esports players following suit [5,8]. Although Formosa et al. [1] has demonstrated a disjointed understanding of esports definitions within the literature, other research has further demonstrated that the lines between esports players and gaming content creators is blurry..

1.2. Current study

We sought to address the uncertainty of definitions for gaming content and esports and aim to answer two calls for action by Formosa et al. [1]:

- 1) for esports definitions to be independent and non-reliant on other domains (e.g., “similar to traditional sports”, “extension of recreational gaming”); and
- 2) for esports definitions to be derived from non-academic contexts.

Although said in the context of esports, the second call for action is also applicable to defining gaming content; definitions within the gaming literature are stuck in an echo chamber filled with only the perspectives of researchers while ignoring the perspectives of those directly involved and affected by such activities, the video gaming community. By branching out, game players and other gaming community members, alternative and challenging knowledge may be gained and can assist in the development of a more multifaceted understanding of esports and gaming content. Therefore, we ask the following research question:

RQ1: How does the gaming community define videogaming-related content and esports?

Furthermore, coinciding with Formosa et al.’s [1] themes within esports literature, and the call to access knowledge outside of academic literature, we asked the following:

RQ2: To what extent do the themes of “esports” in the literature align with the opinions of the gaming community?

Lastly, to further investigate the status of professionalism and occupational status of gaming content creators and esports players, we asked the following:

RQ3: What are the gaming community’s perspectives on playing videogames as an occupation?

2. Method

2.1. Design

A cross-sectional observational research design was used, implementing both quantitative and qualitative methodologies (mixed-methods) to thoroughly address the research questions.

2.2. Participants

To meet a combination of purposive sampling methods and the university’s ethical requirements, participants had to be aged 16 years

or older, proficient in English communication (written), lived in one of 33 countries¹ with a free mental health support hotline, and engaged in one or more of the following six game-related behaviours: 1) play videogames for fun (i.e., recreational gaming); 2) play videogames to earn money; 3) compete in esports events (casually or professionally); 4) watch people play videogames (e.g., live-streams, gameplay, “let’s plays”); 5) watch videos about videogames (e.g., gaming news, theory/lore videos); or 6) involved in sharing videogaming news.

The survey received 235 responses. After removing non-consenting and incomplete responses, the final sample size was $N = 85$ with 64.7 % being recreational players ($n = 55$), 71.8 % of the sample being men ($n = 61$), and the median age being 26yrs (min. = 16yrs, max. = 44yrs); see Table 1. Participants were from one of 18 countries. The countries and frequency groups were as follows: Australia ($n = 33$, 38.8 %); United States ($n = 23$, 27.1 %); the Philippines ($n = 6$, 7.1 %); France, Germany, United Kingdom ($n = 3$, 3.5 %); Canada, New Zealand ($n = 2$, 2.4 %); and China, Hong Kong, India, Malaysia, Netherlands, Norway, Russia, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland ($n = 1$, 1.2 %). Of the $N = 85$ participants, two did not complete the quantitative questionnaire but did provide invaluable qualitative responses, and therefore were included only for the qualitative analysis. Meanwhile, another participant wrote irrelevant responses to the qualitative questions, but genuine responses to the quantitative questionnaire according to their response pattern and response to the reverse scored item; therefore, this participant was included only in the quantitative responses. Thus, the qualitative sample size was $N = 84$, and the quantitative sample size was $N = 83$.

2.3. Materials

An online survey on the Qualtrics platform was used and comprised four sections: 1) screening; 2) demographics; 3) long-response section (qualitative); and 4) Esports Theme Questionnaire section (quantitative).

The qualitative section comprised three unique sub-sections: *Esports*, *videogame Content*, and *Playing videogames as a Job*. Participants were asked how they defined or described the topic, who were involved (i.e., what kind of players, workers, etc.), and what term they would use to describe them (i.e., game-related content creators, players who earn money from gaming). In addition, participants responded to a “yes/no” question regarding whether or not they considered playing videogames a job if they earned money from it: if they answered “yes”, two additional long-response questions were presented asking why they would consider it a job and what they would name said job(s).

We developed an Esports Theme Questionnaire to measure the extent that participants agreed with literature-based esports themes from Formosa et al.’s [1] findings. The questionnaire included a total of 16 Likert-items, with one to three Likert items to measure *competitive gaming*, *organised activity*, *professionalism*, *fans and spectators*, *skills and training*, *extension of gaming*, and *leisure activity*. After group discussion, the *leisure activity* item was re-labelled as a reverse coded item for *professionalism* and became the second professionalism statement (Professionalism 2). In addition, an item asking about esports *platforms and consoles* was added. All Likert items were measured from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*), and were independently scored (i.e., not designed to be summed or averaged). See Table 2 for the full list of questionnaire items and corresponding esports theme.

¹ List of included countries: Australia, Brazil, Canada, China, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Hong Kong, Hungary, India, Indonesia, Italy, Japan, Malaysia, Mexico, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Philippines, Poland, Russia, South Africa, South Korea, Spain, Sri Lanka, Sweden, Switzerland, Thailand, Taiwan, United States of America, United Kingdom, and Vietnam.

2.4. Procedure

Following approval (protocol #206018) from the University of South Australia’s Human Research Ethics Committee, participant recruitment occurred between the 6th of February and the 2nd of July 2024. Three recruitment strategies were used: paid advertisements, native posts, and emails. Paid advertisements were used on Facebook, Instagram, and Reddit. Native posts on X (formerly Twitter), Facebook, and Reddit were posted using the research hub’s social media accounts. When appropriate, hashtags (e.g., #progamer, #videogames) were used to gain further traction by allowing non-followers to see the posts organically on their feed page. In addition, a total of two Facebook groups and nine sub-reddit’s granted permission to advertise the study. Although game-related organisations and clubs were approached via email, only one organisation stated that they shared the survey with their employees.

Individuals who selected the link would be directed to the Qualtrics platform and information page. Those who consented began the screening process. Those who did not consent or did not meet all screening criteria were sent to the end of the survey. Participants completed the demographics section, including player self-identification. Participants then completed the long-response section, followed by the Esports Theme Questionnaire. Before submitting and completing the survey, participants were asked an optional open-ended question for any additional comments, including any elements they thought were missed in the survey. Once completed, participants were shown contact information for a free support hotline for their country (as indicated during the screening process) in case participants felt any emotional distress.

2.5. Analysis approach

2.5.1. Qualitative Data: Template analysis

2.5.1.1. Philosophical Positioning. Due to the nature of the research questions guiding this study, we adopted pragmatism as the leading philosophical paradigm, specifically referencing Marrouf’s [23] reality cycle and double-faced knowledge. Therefore, while many valid definitions for game-related content and esports exist dependent on varying factors (e.g., culture, language, age/generation, etc.), we believe that by observing the themes founded across these definitions, a singular definition can be agreed upon, so long as it is useful [24,25]. Our qualitative approach needed to support both philosophical flexibility while allowing a systematic means of identifying recurring patterns. Template analysis was selected for these reasons.

Template analysis (TA) is a codebook thematic approach that emphasises hierarchical coding and a highly structured analysis process [26,27]. The step-by-step analysis method can facilitate for a range of philosophical underpinnings and adaptations such as reasoning (e.g., inductive, abductive, or deductive) and use of a priori codes that may be theoretical/literature driven or grounded in interview data [26,27,28]. The flexibility, adaptability and systematic process present in TA are most appropriate for research grounded in pragmatism, where other approaches (e.g., reflexive thematic analysis [29]) may not be as advantageous.

2.5.1.2. Template analysis. The standard TA follows a six-step method: 1) familiarisation; 2) preliminary coding; 3) clustering codes to form themes; 4) defining an initial template; 5) testing the initial template; and 6) realising the final template. Movement from step 5 to step 6 can be non-linear with step 5 being an iterative process; the coding template is revised until all data can be coded [26,27,28].

The lead researcher served as the primary analyst, consulting the research team at every step in which revised codes, themes and hierarchies were challenged to form new versions of the coding template. A total of 702 passages of free-text responses were collected; however,

Table 1
Gender, Player Type, and Age Descriptives of the Sample.

	Recreational Player	Esports Players/Staff ^a	Player Type n (%) Game Content Consumer	Game Content Creator	Unknown	Total N (%)
Gender						
Men	39 (70.9)	3 (75)	11 (84.6)	7 (63.3)	1 (50)	61 (71.8)
Women	8 (14.5)	1 (25)	1 (7.7)	2 (18.2)	0	12 (14.1)
Gender Diverse	4 (7.3)	0	0	0	0	4 (4.7)
Prefer not to say	1 (4)	0	1 (7.7)	2 (18.2)	1 (50)	8 (9.4)
Age						
Min.	16	23	20	16	18	16
Max.	43	38	31	44	38	44
Median	28	26.50	25	24	28	26
SD	6.45	7.14	3.76	8.89	8.53	6.47
Total	55 (64.7)	4 (4.71)	13 (15.3)	11 (12.9)	2 (2.35)	85 (100)

^a Two participants self-identified as “something else” and typed out their player description. P32 described themselves as both an esports coach and semi-pro esports player, and P44 described themselves as an organiser of esports events. Therefore, they were coded into the “Esports Players/Staff” identity.

Table 2
Esports Theme Questionnaire with Item Statements and Corresponding Esports Theme.

Esports Item	Item Statement
Competitive	Esports is competitive
Organised 1	Esports is an organised activity
Organised 2	Esports refers to organised events and tournaments only
Professional	Only professional players participate in esports
1	
Professional	Esports is a recreational activity
2	
Professional	Both professional and non-professional players can participate in esports
3	
Fans 1	Esports events can have viewers & spectators
Fans 2	Esports has fans/a fanbase
Skills 1	Players need to have a level of skill to participate in esports
Skills 2	Esports participation requires training & practice
Skills 3	Esports players will train in the lead-up to esports events
Extension 1	Esports is different from regular videogames/gaming
Extension 2	Esports is like videogaming with additional elements (e.g., competitions, training, elite leagues, etc.)
Sports 1	Esports is a sport
Sports 2	Esports is similar to traditional sports
Platforms *	Esports can include gaming platforms beyond PC/computer

Note. * Additional theme added by the authors for exploration.

only 643 responses were used in the analysis after highlighting all relevant data. Responses ranged from 1 to 153 words in length. Following recommendations for quality assurance in TA [27,28], the primary analyst kept an audit trail of all thoughts, discussions, and processes that occurred during the analysis including metadata (e.g., dates, cases in each sub-set), contrasting codes and hierarchies that were not used, and all versions and revisions of the coding template. To align with pragmatism and using abductive reasoning, a combination of a priori themes and data-developed themes were utilised. Two literature-based a priori themes were used; “competitive” and “organised” were selected due to their repeated inclusion in esports definitions [1].

To develop the initial coding template, the analyst used a preliminary sub-set of data consisting of eight randomly selected cases. Through familiarisation, a list of possible codes were identified to be used alongside the two literature-based a priori themes. These codes were then used in NVivo (v. 14) [30], a qualitative data analysis application, to perform preliminary coding with the Preliminary Sub-Set. Unused and underused codes were removed, and new codes were added. We developed a total of 43 codes and clustered them to form themes. During the development of the initial template, the research team decided to develop a coding template for each gaming context (i.e., “game-related content”, “esports”, and “gameplay careers”) to preserve nuance in similar or overlapping codes (e.g., “skill” as a theme for esports players versus “skill” as a career justification). The initial coding

template can be found in the Appendix.

To emphasise the impact of new insight through data interaction, the remaining 76 cases were randomly split into 19 sub-sets, allowing for each following sub-set to provoke template revisions. A total of 12 revisions to the template were made after coding all 19 sub-sets. Provocation to revise the template included relevant data unable to be coded, development of additional codes, or new insights suggesting codes to be reorganised in their clusters or hierarchies. When revisions were made, the provoking sub-set (e.g., Sub-Set 6) would be used again to test the newly revised template (e.g., Template 7) before moving onto to the next sub-set (e.g., Sub-Set 7).

Following King et al.’s [28] recommendations, alternative versions of Template 12 were explored by the research team before defining an anticipated final template. This anticipated final template was tested with all 84 cases and was successful in coding all relevant data without revisions, completing the final step of TA.

2.5.2. Quantitative data

We used IBM SPSS (v. 29) [31], a quantitative statistical analysis application, to perform all statistical analyses. The majority of items ($n = 13$) were non-normally distributed; therefore, we used non-parametric tests including one-sample proportions tests and other measures of central tendency. We checked the assumptions of binomial distribution and minimum success/failure prior to conducting analyses.

3. Results

3.1. Template analysis findings

3.1.1. Game-Related content

See Fig. 1 for the final coding template of game-related content. Numerous key differences from the initial coding template include a more extensive list of content type and sub-types, a list of key elements found in game-related content, and the relationship of creator names.

Participants described a plethora of content that can be found within the videogaming sphere. Most notably, *esports* was named as a form of game-related content rather than being a separate phenomenon, and was identified as a form of *competitive content* (i.e., content depicting competitive gaming) alongside *speedruns*. However, speedrunning content is not always inherently competitive. Speedrunning is described as “*videos or livestreams of game playthroughs, that are optimised in a certain way to be fast as possible*” (P19, 20 yr Man, Recreational Player) indicating speedrunning content can be a type of *gameplay content* (*challenges/mods*); however, when performed in “*community contests like speedrunning*” (P23, 30 yr Man, Game Content Consumer), or used as documentation of speedrun records/attempts, speedrunning becomes a form of competitive content.

Game-related content is vast and does not necessarily conform to the stringent content categories as listed in Fig. 1. The example above with

Game-Related Content

-
- 1. Content “About Games”**
 - 1.1. Extension of Video Games**
 - 1.1.1. Information Dissemination
 - 1.1.1.1. *News*
 - 1.1.1.2. *Extra Gaming Information*
 - 1.1.2. Opinion Pieces
 - 1.1.2.1. *Reviews/Reactions*
 - 1.1.2.2. *Ranking/Tier Lists*
 - 1.1.2.3. *Essays/Analyses/Retrospectives*
 - 1.1.3. Game Theory/Lore
 - 1.2. Vicarious Gaming**
 - 1.2.1. Gameplay
 - 1.2.1.1. *Challenges/Mods*
 - 1.2.2. Tutorials/Guides
 - 1.2.3. Tips, Tricks, & Hacks
 - 1.3. Competitive Content**
 - 1.3.1. Esports
 - 1.3.2. Speedruns
 - 1.4. Fan Made Media**
 - 1.4.1. Animations
 - 1.4.1.1. *Machinima*
 - 1.4.2. Compilations
 - 2. Key Elements of Content**
 - 2.1. Purpose of Content**
 - 2.1.1. Informative
 - 2.1.2. Entertainment
 - 2.1.2.1. *Media Comparisons*
 - 2.2. Format of Content**
 - 2.2.1. Recorded Videos
 - 2.2.1.1. *Short Clips*
 - 2.2.2. Live Streams
 - 2.2.3. Written
 - 2.2.4. Podcasts
 - 2.2.5. Game Additions
 - 2.3. Creator Elements in Content**
 - 2.3.1. Personality
 - 2.3.2. Commentary
 - 2.3.3. Audience
 - 2.3.3.1. *Interaction*
 - 3. Content “About Games”**
 - 3.1. “Content Creator”**
 - 3.2. Based on Format/Platform**
 - 3.3. Based on Content Type**
 - 3.4. Fans/Gamers**
 - 3.5. “Influencer”**

Fig. 1. Final Coding Template for Videogame-Related Content.

speedrunning demonstrated how the same content could be a form of *vicarious gaming* (i.e., enjoying gaming via the content creator) and *competitive content*. Another example is presented by P20: “[it] is mostly an individual player/multiple players thoughts or commentary on what is transpiring within the game or games that are being played” (P20, 24 yr Man, Game Content Creator), indicating some game-related content to be *vicarious gaming* with aspects of *opinion pieces* via the use of *commentary*.

Commentary and *personality* seem to be interconnected in which the creators’ personality dictates if and how they will utilise commentary in their content, with *commentary* and *personality* also connected with *audience*. For example, in *live stream* content formats, viewers can “directly interact” with the creator (P84, 28 yr Man, Recreational Player) through the use of live chats and comments. This direct *interaction* may be why P29 says “Parasocial relationships, wherein the viewers feels that they are friends with the creator, can also occur” (P29, 38 yr Man, Game Content Creator). P20 describes an alternative relationship between the viewer and creator; “nowadays the audience exists as the primary influencers on the creator” (P20, 24 yr Man, Game Content Creator), describing, when combined with P29’s sentiment, a more bidirectional relationship.

Commentary and *personality* can also play a role in how viewers perceive the game-related content, i.e., *informative* and/or *entertainment*. For example, “They are entertaining others while (likely and hopefully) adding unique commentary and perspectives” (P9, 19 yr Gender Diverse, Recreational Player), describing the combination of *commentary* and *personality* (“unique”) as attributes to game-related content being considered as *entertainment*.

“Content creator”, “gaming content creator” or adjacent were often used as umbrella terms when talking about game-related content creators. More specific names used included *based on format/platform* and *based on content type*. Interestingly, regardless of content type, if the creator used Twitch or live-streaming, they were referred to as a “streamer”; further, their content would be referred to as “live streams”. This was a similar pattern for podcasts/podcasters. However, once the content appeared as either *recorded videos* or *written*, the content/content creator were referred to by their content type such as “let’s players”, “reviewers”, and “theorists”. One anomaly to this pattern is VTubers; VTubers “use a digital overlay to hide their identity captured by webcam” in which “an avatar that is motion capture[sic]” (P79, 35 yr Woman, Recreational Player) represents the creator. The use of the digital overlay could be considered the format of the content as it goes beyond just video recording (live-streamed or otherwise), but could also be considered as a content type, and/or additional element in content creation.

3.1.2. Esports

See Fig. 2 for the final coding template of esports. Major differences from the initial coding template included the number of themes to define esports, and the re-organisation of several other themes. Participants described esports as an event, tournament, or competition using one or a combination of the seven sub-themes found in Fig. 2. The theme *competitive* and *professional* separated esports from traditional recreational play, while themes such as *organised*, *live/season-bound*, and *prizes* separated esports from recreational competitive play. For example:

Esports

-
- ```

graph TD
 1[1. Event] --> 1.1[1.1. Competitive]
 1 --> 1.2[1.2. Organised]
 1 --> 1.3[1.3. Professional]
 1 --> 1.4[1.4. Live/Season-Bound]
 1 --> 1.5[1.5. Prizes]
 1 --> 1.6[1.6. Video Games]
 1 --> 1.7[1.7. Digital]
 1.2 --> 1.2.1[1.2.1. Rules]
 1.2 --> 1.2.2[1.2.2. Size]
 1.5 --> 1.5.1[1.5.1. Monetary]
 1.5 --> 1.5.2[1.5.2. Title/Ranking]
 1.6 --> 1.6.1[1.6.1. Game Mode/Genre]
 1.6 --> 1.6.2[1.6.2. Player vs. Player]
 2[2. Players] --> 2.1[2.1. Participation]
 2 --> 2.2[2.2. High Skill/Training]
 2.1 --> 2.1.1[2.1.1. Semi-Professional/Professional]
 2.1.1 --> 2.1.1.1[2.1.1.1. Paid]
 2.1 --> 2.1.2[2.1.2. Amateur/Casual]
 2.1 --> 2.1.3[2.1.3. Team/Solo]
 3[3. Entertainment] --> 3.1[3.1. Commentary]
 3 --> 3.2[3.2. Audience/Fans]
 3 --> 3.3[3.3. Broadcasted]
 4[4. Sponsors] --> 4.1[4.1. Funding Events]
 4 --> 4.2[4.2. Funding Players]
 5[5. Sports Comparison]

```
- 1. Event**
    - 1.1. Competitive
    - 1.2. Organised
      - 1.2.1. Rules
      - 1.2.2. Size
    - 1.3. Professional
    - 1.4. Live/Season-Bound
    - 1.5. Prizes
      - 1.5.1. Monetary
      - 1.5.2. Title/Ranking
    - 1.6. Video Games
      - 1.6.1. Game Mode/Genre
      - 1.6.2. Player vs. Player
    - 1.7. Digital
  - 2. Players**
    - 2.1. Participation
      - 2.1.1. Semi-Professional/Professional
        - 2.1.1.1. Paid
      - 2.1.2. Amateur/Casual
      - 2.1.3. Team/Solo
    - 2.2. High Skill/Training
  - 3. Entertainment**
    - 3.1. Commentary
    - 3.2. Audience/Fans
    - 3.3. Broadcasted
  - 4. Sponsors**
    - 4.1. Funding Events
    - 4.2. Funding Players
  - 5. Sports Comparison**

Fig. 2. Final Coding Template for Esports.

In my eyes a[sic] esports needs to have something like an organization that oversees the competitions, holds tournaments / leagues etc. For example, in the context of the Tekken World tour hosted by Bandai Namco, Tekken is an esports. In the context of speedrunning the Tekken story mode, Tekken is not an esports, as the competition there us[sic] organized in the community with no real-time competition. (P12, 29 yr Man, Recreational Player).

The above quote captures the themes of organisation (*organised*) and time sensitivity (*live/season-bound*) to distinguish esports from casual competitive play (of esports genre games), and from speedrunning (discussed in game-related content). P12 also uses the theme of *game mode/genre* to differentiate these phenomena, explaining how one videogame can be considered an esports and not an esports simultaneously.

An array of *video game* genres and formats were described, including in-game battles (multiplayer games), out-of-game battles (score/performance comparisons), first-person shooter, fighter games, and battle arenas (more broadly). However, there does not seem to be a consensus on whether esports are “*sport-based genre games*” or “*digital-first genre games*”. For example, P5 described esports as “*when people play videogames about sports like football, racing, etc.*” (P5, 23 yr Man, Game Content Creator); whereas P66 explicitly states “*FIFA is not a[sic] esports since it can be played as a sport*” (P66, 30 yr Man, Amateur Esports Player).

In contrast, P56 describes esports games to be neither sports-based or not-sports-based games, but rather as *digital first games*:

*Playing competitive digital first games (as opposed to digital implementations of traditionally non-digital games; e.g., a professional poker player who only plays in online casinos is not what I would personally consider an esports player, because poker is/can be played entirely without a digital platform/interface; whereas something like Counter-Strike or Fighter is specifically a bespoke digital experience that cannot be perfectly replicated in a non-digital format).* (P56, 33 yr Man, Recreational Player).

P56 describes that esports is not just competition similar to traditional sports based in the digital realm but is specifically videogames that are dependent on the digital interface for the competition to be performed.

Players were, for the most part, described as simply anyone who participated in esports events. However, this participation varies from amateur casual participation to professional participation; P27 explained the following:

*Playing at local or abroad tournaments competitively can make you an esports player. You would be amateur, but you would still be an esports player. Then there would be the semi-pro esports players who don't play their selected esports for a living but have high gaming skill, play at a high level consistently, have teamwork, strategies and tactics, practice, and lots of dedication to the esports. Then you have the professionals who's[sic] job it is to play their selected esports. They would be Professional Esport Players.* (P27, 29 yr Man, Recreational Player).

Further, P57 said “*this is a sliding scale – for instance you can be a rower who competes at a local, state, or international level. This is the same for esports*” (P57, 25 yr Woman, Recreational Player) supporting the notion of participation occurring on a spectrum. This spectrum also appears to coincide with the players *Skill*:

*Anyone of any skill level can participate and enjoy esports. Either as players, other involved staff or audience. They don't require a prerequisite level of skill unless you want to go big time and win, then you'd need to train and improve skills like any athlete.* (P84, 28 yr Man, Recreational Player).

For players to move along the professionalism spectrum, they must partake in training and improve their skill while those who are already at a professional level already retain a high level of skill.

Participants also described how esports casters provide *commentary* during esports events, providing additional *entertainment* value for fans. Furthermore, esports events with *sponsors* are *broadcasted* for live-view, consequently becoming a form of game-related content.

### 3.1.3. Gameplay careers

Participants were asked if they would consider playing videogames a job if they were paid; 96.5 % indicated ‘yes’ ( $n = 82$ ), and 3.5 % indicated ‘no’ ( $n = 3$ ). Those who said ‘yes’ were asked for their justification and what kind of people would fall into this category. See Fig. 3 for the final coding template of gameplay careers. The primary difference from the initial coding template was the addition of a career area, along with new justifications.

Participants described three clear areas in which playing a videogame is an occupation: *esports*, *game-related content creation*, and *game testers*. The last sub-theme found in *professional areas*, *ambiguous*, detailed videogame playing as a profession, but did not detail if the professions were in the realm of esports, content creation, or game testing.

When participants had to justify why they considered playing

Gameplay Careers

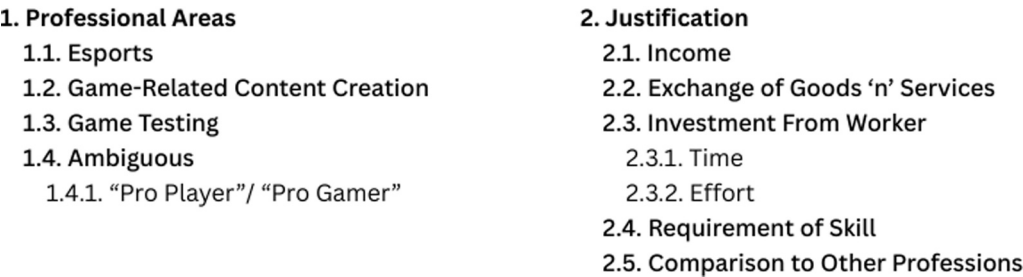


Fig. 3. Final Coding Template for Gameplaying Careers.

videogames as a profession, *income* was the most prominent justification. However, similar to esports, participants reasoning presented combinations of the five sub-themes found in Fig. 3. For example, mention of *exchange of goods ‘n’ services* also included mention of *income* such as being paid for the service provided by the professional players. *Investment from worker* in the form of *time* or *effort* were commonly found together; however, *investment from worker* was also used to differentiate gaming as a hobby and gaming as a job. Most notable is P76’s comment:

*Most people don’t want to do esports, despite most people playing videogames. They must be different things if phenomenologically people can say “I like playing x” but then say “I don’t want to do that for a job” or feign confusion at professional players.*  
(P76, 30 yr Woman, Recreational Player).

The above quote exemplifies that the simple act of gaming is not what defines the action as a job or not; rather, the dedication and required additional actions are what make gaming a job, beyond just a hobby (i.e., recreational gaming).

3.2. Quantitative statistical tests

The distribution of data across the 16 esports theme items were checked prior to analyses. See Table 3 for descriptive data.

Self-identified player type and gaming behaviour variables were recoded into individual binary variables to see if there was a relationship between the two; phi coefficients were calculated and are reported in Table 4. Eight associations were significant with medium to large effect sizes according to Cohen’s [32] benchmarks. Notably, self-identifying as a game content creator had significant and large associations with game

content creator behaviours. In addition, self-identifying as an esports player/staff had a significant moderate positive association with competing in esports events, and significant medium-to-large negative associations with recreational gaming behaviours.

3.2.1. Proportion Comparisons: Agree versus Disagree

We used the one-sample proportion test to determine if significantly more than half of the sample agreed/disagreed on the 16 esports theme items. The assumption of binomial distribution was met by determining a cut-point of 4, indicating 4 (agree) and 5 (strongly agree) as success (1; “agree”); scores 3 and below (neutral, disagree, and strongly disagree) were defined as failure (0; “disagree”). The test value was set as 0.50 to see if the rate of success was significantly higher than 50 %. Minimum *n* = 15 for success and failure were not met for *n* = 7 esports theme items; therefore, the Agresti-Coull corrected confidence intervals [33,34] and the Yate’s continuity corrected significance and Z-scores [35] were used. All proportion test results are reported in Table 5.

All but one test was statistically significant: Sports 2 (“Esports is similar to traditional sports”) success rate was not significantly greater than 50 %, receiving a total of 45 (54.22 %) successes, *Z* = 0.66, *p* = 0.51, *h* = 0.09. All other proportion comparisons were significant, with success rates between 61.45 % and 96.39 %, and significance ranging between *p* = 0.048 and *p* < 0.001. Effect sizes ranged from small (*h* = 0.23) to large (*h* = 1.19) [32].

4. Discussion

Using mixed methodologies, we sought to develop clear definitions and then comprehensively describe the nature of videogaming-related content and esports from the gaming community’s perspective. Furthermore, we explored the stance of the gaming community towards playing videogames as a career, and their justifications.

Using game-related entertainment as an umbrella term encompassing all content related to gaming captures a wide array of media. Specific content such as gameplay [3,10,11,13,14,15,16,19,20,36], tutorials [13], reviews/reactions [11,13,36], and game additions (mods/modifications [17]) have previously been explored in the literature. However, other content identified in this study have not. Content discussing and extending on videogames and community (e.g., game theory, video essays, news) may be central to the pivotal role gaming content has on gaming culture [13,16,17]. In social groups, gossip (i.e., information dissemination) assists in social community learning systems, maintenance and reinforcement of social community boundaries, and upholding moral values in the community [37]. This can be seen in game-related news and video essays reporting on creator or company controversies or cultural events (e.g., GamerGate). Simultaneously, content discussing videogames (e.g., essays, theories) extend and maintain the life of a videogame, attracting and connecting community members of similar interests [38]. By capturing and detailing the range of what game-related content is provides further context of the possible purposes

Table 3  
Descriptive Data Displaying Measures of Central Tendency (Mean, Median, Mode), and Standard Deviation for the Esports Themes Items.

| Esports theme item | Mean | Median | Mode | SD   |
|--------------------|------|--------|------|------|
| Competitive        | 4.72 | 5      | 5    | 0.63 |
| Organised 1        | 4.43 | 5      | 5    | 0.74 |
| Organised 2        | 3.58 | 4      | 4    | 1.17 |
| Professional 1     | 2.51 | 2      | 2    | 1.14 |
| Professional 2     | 3.06 | 3      | 3    | 1.00 |
| Professional 3     | 3.98 | 4      | 4    | 1.06 |
| Fans 1             | 4.80 | 5      | 5    | 0.49 |
| Fans 2             | 4.54 | 5      | 5    | 0.69 |
| Skills 1           | 3.96 | 4      | 5    | 1.18 |
| Skills 2           | 4.06 | 4      | 5    | 1.13 |
| Skills 3           | 4.54 | 5      | 5    | 0.65 |
| Extension 1        | 4.07 | 4      | 5    | 0.99 |
| Extension 2        | 4.25 | 4      | 5    | 0.90 |
| Sports 1           | 3.76 | 4      | 5    | 1.16 |
| Sports 2           | 3.42 | 4      | 4    | 1.22 |
| Platforms          | 4.66 | 5      | 5    | 0.59 |

Note. Likert-type scale values are as follows: 1 = strongly disagree; 2 = disagree; 3 = neutral; 4 = agree; 5 = strongly agree.

**Table 4**

Phi Correlation Associations Between Player Types and Game-Related Behaviours.

|                  | Recreational Player | Esports Players / Staff | Game Content Consumer | Player Type<br>Game Content Creator | Something Else |
|------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------|
| Game Behaviour 1 | .15                 | -.49**                  | .05                   | .04                                 | .02            |
| Game Behaviour 2 | -.38**              | .09                     | -.16                  | .62***                              | .06            |
| Game Behaviour 3 | -.17                | .32**                   | .06                   | .001                                | -.08           |
| Game Behaviour 4 | .002                | -.21*                   | -.03                  | .15                                 | .07            |
| Game Behaviour 5 | .01                 | -.29**                  | .03                   | .128                                | .05            |
| Game Behaviour 6 | -.40***             | .20                     | -.02                  | .39***                              | .14            |

Note. Game Behaviour codes are as follows: 1) play video games for fun; 2) play video games to earn money; 3) compete in esports events (casually or professionally); 4) watch people play games; 5) watch video games about games; and 6) involved in reporting and sharing news about video games/gaming. Effect size reported is  $\phi$  (phi) [32].

\* associations are significant at  $p < 0.05$ ; \*\* associations are significant at  $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\* associations are significant at  $p < 0.001$ .

**Table 5**

One-Sample Proportion Test Results for the 16 Items on the Esports Theme Questionnaire.

| Item           | Agreed (n) | Proportion agreed | 95 % CI <sup>a</sup> |     | Z <sup>b</sup> Score | p <sup>b</sup> |  | h <sup>c</sup> |
|----------------|------------|-------------------|----------------------|-----|----------------------|----------------|--|----------------|
|                |            |                   | LL                   | UL  |                      | (two-tailed)   |  |                |
| Competitive    | 77         | .93               | .85                  | .97 | 7.68                 | < .001         |  | 1.03           |
| Organised 1    | 75         | .90               | .82                  | .95 | 7.24                 | < .001         |  | 0.94           |
| Organised 2    | 51         | .61               | .51                  | .71 | 1.98                 | <b>.048</b>    |  | 0.23           |
| Professional 1 | 19         | .23               | .15                  | .33 | -4.83                | < .001         |  | 0.57           |
| Professional 2 | 27         | .33               | .23                  | .43 | -3.07                | <b>.002</b>    |  | 0.36           |
| Professional 3 | 63         | .76               | .66                  | .84 | 4.61                 | < .001         |  | 0.55           |
| Fans 1         | 80         | .96               | .90                  | .99 | 8.34                 | < .001         |  | 1.19           |
| Fans 2         | 78         | .94               | .86                  | .98 | 7.90                 | < .001         |  | 1.08           |
| Skill 1        | 61         | .74               | .63                  | .82 | 4.17                 | < .001         |  | 0.49           |
| Skill 2        | 64         | .77               | .67                  | .85 | 4.83                 | < .001         |  | 0.57           |
| Skill 3        | 76         | .92               | .83                  | .96 | 7.46                 | < .001         |  | 0.98           |
| Extension 1    | 65         | .78               | .68                  | .86 | 5.05                 | < .001         |  | 0.60           |
| Extension 2    | 69         | .83               | .74                  | .90 | 5.93                 | < .001         |  | 0.72           |
| Sport 1        | 53         | .64               | .53                  | .73 | 2.42                 | < .016         |  | 0.28           |
| Sport 2        | 45         | .54               | .44                  | .66 | 0.66                 | .510           |  | 0.09           |
| Platforms      | 78         | .94               | .86                  | .98 | 7.90                 | < .001         |  | 1.08           |

Note. Score (continuity corrected) values were reported for Z-score and p (two-tailed). CI = confidence interval; LL = lower limit; UL = upper limit. Significant p values are in bold.

<sup>a</sup> Agresti-Coull CI reported [33,34]. <sup>b</sup> Yate's continuity corrected statistics reported [35]. <sup>c</sup> Cohen's h calculated using Cohen's [32] formula:  $h = \phi_1 - \phi_2$  in which  $\phi = 2 \times \arcsin \sqrt{P}$  [p. 181].

and functions these media have, and further, its importance in gaming culture.

Game-related entertainment encompasses a range of multifaceted content identified in the present study and previous literature. Therefore, through the lens of our results we propose that game-related entertainment can be defined as follows:

*Game-related entertainment is content surrounding the world of gaming including gaming in action (competitive, informative, or leisure), discussion of videogames, or expanding the world of a videogame through any media platform or format.*

Regarding esports, interestingly, participants did not define esports as being independent of the broader game-related content. Rather, the gaming community viewed esports events and esports-related media to be a form of *competitive content* along with speedrunning. This reconceptualisation of esports being within the game-related content may explain why we see behavioural overlap such as esports players also doing gameplay streaming or transitioning into game-related content as their main career.

However, esports and speedrunning are not the same, activity- or content-wise. Most of the gaming community participants agreed with literature-based themes presented, demonstrating validity in using themes of competitiveness, organisation, fans, skill, and esports as an extension of videogaming. When asked to define esports independently, we developed themes that were congruent with previous esports definitions such as competitive, organisation, videogames, and prizes [1,2,3,4,5,7,11,21,22]. However, we developed a new theme: esports events being season-bound. This key aspect is critical in distinguishing esports events and participation from other competitive content such as

speedrunning, or from recreational or non-professional esports play (e.g., playing an esports genre game out of season, similar to a soccer player playing soccer outside of a tournament season).

Both qualitative and quantitative findings revealed a complex relationship between esports and sport identity, and between esports and professionalism. In the quantitative analyses participants considered esports to be a sport, but not similar to traditional ones. When further contextualised with the qualitative findings, it is evident that participants use traditional sport comparisons to explain concepts, such as the presence of commentators, sponsorships, rules, referees, and more. Therefore, although esports may not be described as a sport (thematically), sport comparisons and sport identity are used to argue the validity and legitimacy of the activity and profession. Regarding professionalism, although participants agreed that esports was professional in both data forms, they also agreed that both professional and non-professional players could engage in esports. That is, the level of professionalism for esports exists on a spectrum. Participants described esports participation to vary from casual or amateur participation to elite and professional participation, describing a spectrum that coincides with previous research [2,5,7,8,10]. We postulate that the theme of professionalism has arisen due to an over-saturation of high-level professional esports events. Events that are "professional" are more likely to be broadcasted whereas smaller events are not, resulting in over-exposure of professional athletes and under-representation of amateur athletes, similar to traditional sports. Therefore, rather than being a pivotal aspect in defining esports, "professional" is a fluctuating attribute that may or may not be present. Therefore, in the context of the body of literature, our qualitative findings and quantitative results, we propose that esports can be best defined as follows:



*Esports are competitive and organised season-bound videogaming events in which players and events vary in size, professionalism, sponsorships, prizes, and media coverage.*

With game-related entertainment and esports defined, the conversation diverts to career prospects. Most participants agreed that playing videogames could be a career, especially when income and exchange of products or services are considered. Coinciding with Karl Marx's labor theory of value in the esports context [11], esports players work can evolve from use-value to exchange-value whereby players are rewarded with money (i.e., "players "get paid to play"; p. 741) and becomes a career (professional esports player). This argument can be extended to other gaming content creators who earn money for their gameplaying endeavours, similarly transitioning from use-value to exchange-value. Further, the gaming community by their own accord place value on the content made by gaming content creators and believe these workers should be rewarded for their services and products, thereby transforming immaterial play-labour to material play-labour.

The position of gameplaying as a potential career is not new, with research investigating professional esports players [2,3,5,6,10,39], professional gameplay live-streamers [14,15,16,17] and professional gameplay YouTubers (let's players) [13,15]. However, the present findings provide two additional discussion points: 1) game-testing was identified as a gameplay career; and 2) the gaming community support and identify gameplay work as valued and valid careers. These findings present many opportunities for future research to better understand what these careers look like in reality, such as identifying job tasks, work schedules, income forms and salary type. With such information, governmental bodies will be able to identify these workers in industry and occupational classification systems (e.g., Occupational Standard Classification of Australia, United States Standard Occupational Classification system) that can standardise their working practices and workers' rights.

## 5. Limitations

The lack of diversity of the sample is the primary limitation. Participants were primarily recreational players with minimal esports representation, players or otherwise such as the esports organisations or governing bodies. Therefore, there was an under-representation of esports personnel who are directly affected by the definitions of esports. Although, content consumers did consist of esports-content consumers and could provide insights for esports definitions, this may have provided biased esports themes from the consumer perspective.

In addition to a lack of player diversity, there was also a lack of geographical and cultural diversity of the present study. Of the sample, 11.77 % of participants were from Asian countries (China, Hong Kong, India, Malaysia, and the Philippines); however, research has indicated esports and other gaming markets to be most prominent in Asian countries [40] and over 50 % of gamers are from the Asia-Pacific [41]. The limited representation of Asian-based gaming community members may be attributed to language barriers as English-proficiency was an inclusion criterion. Future research should seek to explore and report the experiences and opinions of Asian-based gaming community members.

Finally, we did not include an open-ended question inviting participants to explain why they disagreed with the statement that playing videogames could be considered a valid career. In hindsight, this omission may have limited our understanding of alternative perspectives. At the time of survey design, we anticipated that the majority of participants would not view gameplaying as a career, therefore, focused on collecting rationale from those who agreed. Future studies should ensure that both those who agree and disagree with statements such as this are equally given the opportunity to expand on this to gain a more balanced understanding of community perspectives.

## 5.1. Future research

The current study presents definitions for game-related content and esports based on community and literature perspectives. However, future research can further explore how we can use these definitions as well as establish further metrics for external validity. For example, the presented esports definition should be reviewed by esports-based community members such as players, coaches, and esports organising bodies to ensure all nuances are captured and for clarification of complex themes (e.g., sports identity). Further, a systematic review of all articles discussing game-related content should be conducted to collate all available information. This may include the use of content types listed in this article or to cross-validate what game-related content is discussed or defined in academic research.

Future research could also expand on the findings presented in this study. Namely, the exploration of the genres and sub-genres of game-related content, their associated communities and audiences, and the role they play in gaming culture. Although vicarious gaming has been studied (e.g., streaming, let's plays), opinion pieces (e.g., video essays or game reviews) or information videos (e.g., news) have not. The audiences that are attracted to one genre and not another may be telling of cultural shifts and how they can be influenced (e.g., rise and fall of GamerGate). Further, research exploring gameplaying as career should be explored more through occupational and organisational lenses, such as the implications of worker rights, occupational classification, and career prospectives.

## 5.2. Conclusions

Game-related content is a multifaceted phenomenon that may play a larger role in the videogaming community. From information dissemination and videogame help to entertainment via competitive gameplay. The creators behind this content are also valued highly by the community, with their work perceived as valued careers. Game-related content has been undervalued in its role in the gaming community and how future careers in videogaming may be changing. It is time we zoom out from the individual pixels on the screen; instead of looking at esports or content creators separately, let us look at game-related entertainment as an expansive open-world game with an array of characters, evolving goals and relationships, and a rich interconnected universe.

## CRediT authorship contribution statement

**Louise H. Trudgett-Klose:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Sarven S. McLinton:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Methodology, Conceptualization. **Susannah Emery:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Conceptualization. **David H. Gleaves:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Methodology, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

## Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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## Appendix

Initial Coding Template for Each Gaming Content

### Game-Related Content

#### 1. Entertainment

##### 1.1. Personality

##### 1.2. Video Games

###### 1.2.1. Vicarious Gaming

###### 1.2.2.1. Challenges/Mods

###### 1.2.2. Informative

###### 1.2.2.1. Tutorials/Guides

###### 1.2.2.2. Tips 'n' Tricks

###### 1.2.2.3. News

###### 1.2.3. Reviews

###### 1.2.3.1. Written Work

###### 1.2.4. Esports Content

###### 1.2.5. Other

###### 1.2.5.1. Theory

###### 1.2.5.2. Video Essays

###### 1.2.5.3. Podcasts

#### 2. Content Creator

##### 2.1. Platform

###### 2.1.1. YouTube

###### 2.1.2. Twitch

##### 2.2. Recording Format

###### 2.2.1. Pre-Recorded/Edited

###### 2.2.2. Live/Live-Streamed

###### 2.2.2.1. Short Clips

##### 2.3. Content Type

##### 2.4. Aversion to "Influencer"

#### 3. Audience

### Esports

#### 1. Players

##### 1.1. Participation

###### 1.1.1. Professional

###### 1.1.2. Casual

##### 1.2. Team/Solo

##### 2.2. High Skill/Training

#### 2. Event

##### 2.1. Competitive

###### 2.1.1. Skill

##### 2.2. Organised

###### 2.2.1. Rules

#### 3. Finance

##### 3.1. Prize

##### 3.2. Money

##### 3.3. Sponsors

#### 4. Audience

##### 4.1. In-Person

##### 4.2. Online (Broadcasted)

##### 4.3. Fans

#### 5. Sports Comparison

### Gameplay Careers

#### 1. Professional Areas

##### 1.1. Esports

##### 1.2. Content Creation

#### 2. Justification

##### 2.1. Income

##### 2.2. Work/Effort/Action

##### 2.3. Skill

##### 2.4. Time

## Data availability

De-identified data may be made available upon reasonable request to the corresponding author.

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